or labelled sculptures, no coins carrying royal portraiture or the names of kings and queens, not even palaces or communications emanating from such places and people, have endured.

It is this pervasive absence of royal voices that makes Ashoka stand out as an irresistible historical subject. There are other reasons as well for the interest in him. In relation to his predecessors, he was the first Indian king to rule over an empire embracing much of India and its western borderlands, from Afghanistan to Orissa and towards the south as far as Karnataka. In relation to the rulers who followed him, it was his example which influenced thought—philosophical, religious, cultural—in Asia more profoundly than that of any other political figure of antiquity. The appeal of Ashoka as a model of rulership, even in his own lifetime, is clear from the way in which the Lankan king Devanampiya Tissa (*c*. 247–207 BCE) is said to have established the Buddhist faith in Lanka. This happened after Ashoka sent him gifts which were used for his second coronation, and a message encouraging him to take refuge in the Buddha.[3] Ashoka's influence, much after his time, is unmistakable because he became an icon among Buddhist rulers, 'the great precedent and model of some of the emergent polities of South and Southeast Asia.'[4] In China, for instance, his shaping influence became discernible from the directions taken by several rulers. Emperor Wu of the Liang dynasty (502–49 CE) is an example of a ruler who tried to emulate Ashoka by erecting stupas and forbidding the consumption of alcohol and meat; the Chinese empress Wu Zetian (623/625–705 CE), at least initially, followed suit by projecting herself as a wheel-turning monarch or 'chakravartin', an image of Buddhist kingship closely associated with Ashoka.[5] H.G. Wells had this in mind when, in his massive bestseller of the 1920s, *The Outline of History*, he said that amidst

> the tens of thousands of names of monarchs that crowd the columns of history, their majesties and graciousnesses, and serenities and royal highnesses and the like, the name of Ashoka shines, and shines almost alone, a star. From the Volga to Japan, his name is still honoured. China, Tibet, and